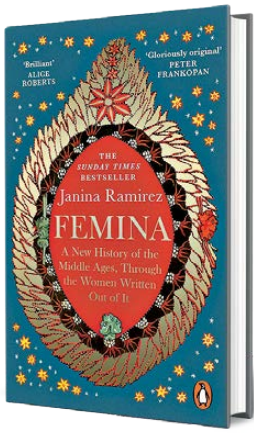
LOOKING FOR WOMEN

Janina Ramirez's *Femina* tries to right the wrongs of history by resurrecting the medieval women who were erased from it



FEMINA
A New History of the Middle Ages, Through the Women Written Out of It
by Janina Ramirez
W.H. ALLEN
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For relief from contemporary feminist fatigue and energy for the struggle forth, Oxford historian Janina Ramirez asks that we look backward. It's easy to feel sceptical—I was too—that the seventh century can hold role models. But Ramirez's method is persuasive: she meticulously mines archaeological records for women, while simultaneously re-reading the *Ecclesiastical History of the English People* written by the medieval monk-scholar Bede.

The 'Venerable Bede', as he is known, is regarded as something of a father of English History. He has been concerned with the lives of great men—bishops, warriors and kings—but his book also features powerful and significant women throughout; they are simply not fleshed out. Ramirez's work lies in adding flesh to medieval women, often accompanied by their literal bones.

THE 'GREAT MEN THEORY'—A PRACTICE OF SEEING HISTORY AS COMPOSED OF STORIES OF GREAT MEN—HAS LONG CAUSED WOMEN TO FADE FROM HISTORY

One such archaeological unearthing is 'the Loftus princess', a title Ramirez uses to refer to a collection of bones found in a seventh-century grave in northern England. The Loftus princess shows the two archaeological signs of having been a woman of power: she has been buried in her bed and with her jewellery. From these bejewelled remains, Ramirez goes back to the writings of the Venerable Bede, to show us that certain seventh-century Northern women were warrior-like, rich, respected, and with the same opportunities as the men around them. We start to reimagine the Loftus princess as one of those powerful women.

The Loftus princess is one of many resurrections that allow Ramirez to refute the romantic idea of the medieval woman as a product of the Victorian male imagination. No lovely frail creature here, no woman working on her embroidery in an isolated tower waiting for her knight to return. We have been had, she tells us, by what historians now call the Great Men Theory. First attributed to British historian Thomas Carlyle, the Great Men Theory is a practice of seeing history as composed of the stories of great men. It's a practice that causes women—and men who are considered insignificant—to fade from history.

Within the discipline of history, the effect of the Great Men theory has been a long-standing resistance to letting women in. When in 2017, a team of Swedish archaeologists—mostly women—declared that they had uncovered a woman in a 10th-century Viking grave, they were met with circumspection and online hate mail. This lack of disciplinary imagination—which makes the idea of an exceptional warrior woman in the male-dominated Viking world impossible—is the darkness from which Ramirez delivers reprieve. *Femina: A New History of the Middle Ages, Through the Women Written Out of It* is not just a rather interesting list of found medieval women; it is a compendium of inventive methodological possibilities with which to search for women in history. ■

Amrita Narayanan